

influence on Elgar's career. Alice was intelligent and gifted: she wrote poetry and had published a novel. She gave Elgar emotional security and boosted his confidence. She also taught him to handle contacts with a higher social stratum and, importantly, had a private income that boosted his slim earnings. His first successful composition, the tuneful *Salut d'amour*, written for Alice on their engagement, premiered in 1889, the year of their marriage. Their only child was born in 1890.

Following a brief sojourn in London, the couple returned to rural Worcestershire, settling near the Malvern Hills. Through the 1890s Elgar had built a reputation as a composer of choral works, from *The Black Knight*, premiered in Worcester in 1893 (see [box](#)), to *Caractacus*, featured at the Leeds Festival in 1898. To the general public, however, he was a complete unknown when the first performances of the *Enigma Variations* in 1899 brought him national renown. Dedicated to "my friends pictured within," the conceit of a series of character studies allowed the *Variations* to cover a wide emotional range, by turns grave and humorous, melancholy and exhilarating. The "enigma" referred to in the title was never explained, but no doubt aided the work's popular success.